



Routledge Research in Language Education

CRITICAL LITERACY WITH ADOLESCENT ENGLISH LANGUAGE LEARNERS

**EXPLORING POLICY AND PRACTICE IN
GLOBAL CONTEXTS**

Jennifer H. Alford



Critical Literacy with Adolescent English Language Learners

This book examines critical literacy within language and literacy learning, with a particular focus on English as an Additional Language learners in schools who traditionally are not given the same exposure to critical literacy as native-English speakers. An important and innovative addition to extant literature, this book explains how English language teachers understand critical literacy and enact it in classrooms with adolescent English language learners from highly diverse language backgrounds.

This book brings together the study of two intersecting phenomena: how critical literacy is constructed in English language education policy for adolescent English language learners internationally and how critical literacy is understood and enacted by teachers amid the so-called 'literacy crisis' in neoliberal eduscapes. The work traces the ways critical literacy has been represented in English language education policy for adolescents in five contexts: Australia, England, Sweden, Canada and the United States. Drawing on case study research, it provides a comparative analysis of how policy in these countries constructs critical literacy, and how this then positions critical engagement as a focus for teachers of English language learners.

Empirically based and accessibly written, this timely book will be of interest to a wide range of academics in the fields of adolescent literacy education, English language learning and teaching, education policy analysis, and critical discourse studies. It will also appeal to teachers, post-graduate students and language education policy makers.

Jennifer Alford is Associate Professor in the School of Teacher Education and Leadership (Faculty of Creative Industries, Education, and Social Justice) at Queensland University of Technology, Brisbane, Australia. She is a founding member of the global Transnational Critical Literacies Network (TCLN) and co-editor of the *Routledge Handbook of Critical Literacies*.

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Global Contexts

Jennifer H. Alford

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This book is dedicated to teachers of English language learners in schools everywhere who make critical literacy a reality despite policy and contextual constraints; and especially to Margot, Riva, Celia and Lucas (pseudonyms), the participants in my original study, who allowed me to inhabit their classrooms, probe their thinking, and learn much from them.

And to my partner Andrew, and daughters Jolie, Mara & Ella, for their buoyant love and support.



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Foreword

Jennifer Alford's book is a gift to teachers, language and literacy researchers, students learning English as an additional language, and me. She gives an account of four teachers' classroom practice as they embed critical literacy into their work with English language learners that is inspiring for other teachers. She analyses what they say about critical literacy in interviews using Systemic Functional Linguistics (Halliday, 1985) in conjunction with Fairclough's approach to Critical Discourse Analysis (1989) that offers a model for other researchers. She shows English language learners' capacity to deconstruct texts in order to understand how they are positioned and positioning, demonstrating that deficit constructions of additional language learners are not warranted. I take great pleasure in her use of my interdependent model of critical literacy (Janks, 2010) as a measure of the teachers' approach to critical literacy and pushes it beyond my conception of it by thinking of it additively in relation to the affordances of different kinds of interdependence. She also includes the important dimension of affect missing from my model. No researcher could ask for more.

Alford distinguishes herself with her grasp of curriculum policy across contexts, the breadth of her understanding of critical literacy, her respect for teachers and an understanding of the constraints of time and policy that limit what is possible for them to achieve. She writes reader friendly prose that takes access for teachers and student teachers seriously. Her focus on critical literacy in the teaching of English as an additional language is an important contribution to the fields of both language education and critical literacy. In much the same way as scholars such as Vasquez (2004) and Comber (2015) demonstrated that young children are able to understand the relationship between language and power, Alford shows conclusively that English language learners in secondary schools can use their current levels of proficiency to read both with and against texts. Because the teaching of additional languages makes language structures explicit, this can be used to push students to consider the effects of particular linguistic choices, an advantage for a critical approach to texts.

Alford's research shows that while the teachers focus on the power and access dimensions of my model in their teaching of critical literacy, they do little with the linguistic, cultural, and knowledge diversity that their learners embody.

Design, where it exists at all, is limited to writing and redesign is a notable absence. It is as if critical literacy has been frozen at an earlier moment in time. The hey-day of critical literacy in Australia was when critical literacy was in its infancy and the focus was on deconstructing texts. The problem with stopping with the oppressive power of texts, is that it leaves students without agency or the ability to effect change. At that time, teachers' critical literacy practice was supported by extensive professional development, the value of which can still be seen in older teachers. This has been lacking as critical literacy has developed to take seriously Freire's understanding that literacy is a force for social transformation, understanding the word and the world in order to change both. The concept of redesign encapsulates the importance of changing the wor(l)d in the interests of social justice. This implies writing back as Celia (Chapter 4) requires of her students when she asks them to address oppression in a persuasive text modelled on political speeches.

In countries where English is the dominant language and anglonormativity (McKinney, 2016) prevails, English language learners experience linguistic marginalisation. Because language is not the only marker of identity it is possible that their marginalisation may be further compounded by their race, gender, class, religion, and/or ethnicity. These are students who understand the effects of power on them and their families. Bringing their diversity into the classroom serves to validate their languages, funds of knowledge and different perspectives. The differences between their languages can serve as a resource for learning English and for language awareness more generally. Questions such as how their different languages signify plurality, gender, or possession are interesting in their own right and serve to examine the differences of the target language. Differences in culture and experience, serve to denaturalise the taken-for-granted assumptions of texts and genres and provide a resource for reading English texts otherwise. If one is outside the codes of a text, it is easier to deconstruct it.

If students' diversity is included in the classroom, it becomes easier to problematise their experiences in Australia, their neighbourhoods, and their school, that they can work to transform. Surveys, letters to the newspaper, articles for the school magazine, persuasive speeches, petitions, social media posts, posters, blogs are all ways of using multimodal literacies for transformation, that teachers can encourage their learners to employ to effect change, to redesign practices, and to develop their own agency. Students can also use literacy in support of other youth movements such as climate change, gun control or Black Lives Matter. In the last chapters of this book, Alford looks at how critical literacy needs to move beyond both monolingual and monomodal conceptions of language education and the deconstructive moment in critical literacy. She focuses on the importance of an expanded notion of critical literacy in the era of post-truth. Where policy remains wedded to conservative agendas, standardized testing and ever greater prescription, it is up to teachers, teacher educators and teacher organisations to lead the way. Alford maps the territory and provides us with a direction worth following.

Hilary Janks (University of the Witwatersrand, Johannesburg, South Africa)

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Preface

Critical Literacy with Adolescent English Language Learners: Exploring Policy and Practice in Global Contexts is the first academic study of two intersecting phenomena: how critical literacy is constructed in English language education policy for adolescent English language learners internationally, and how critical literacy is understood and enacted by teachers of adolescent English language learners amid the so-called ‘literacy crisis’ in neoliberal eduscapes. Critical literacy is an approach to language and literacy learning that investigates language in use to identify assumptions and beliefs underpinning texts, and to explore whose interests are served. English language learners in schools are often not given the same exposure to critical literacy as their English-speaking counterparts because it is seen as “too difficult” for them (Lau, 2012; Locke & Cleary, 2011). This book focusses on both critical literacy policy and practice with these particular learners, and is therefore an important addition to extant literature.

This work traces the ways critical literacy is represented in English language education policy for adolescents in five countries – Australia, United Kingdom, Canada, Sweden and the United States. It provides a comparative analysis of how policy in these countries constructs critical literacy, and how this then positions critical engagement with texts as a teaching focus for teachers of English language learners. Despite the fact that Australia led the way in incorporating critical literacy into official curricula in the 1990s, an erosion of critical engagement with texts has occurred in policy as governments and policy-makers are increasingly seduced by pre-packaged curricula with a focus on measurable basics. Teachers, however, convinced of the efficacy of critical literacy for English language learners, continue to teach critical literacy at the chalkface in a range of powerful ways (Alford & Kettle, 2017).

Critical Literacy with Adolescent English Language Learners explains how English language teachers understand critical literacy, and how they design lessons using it, and enact it in classrooms with adolescent English language learners from highly diverse language backgrounds. Drawing on empirical case study research conducted in Australia, this book provides detailed exploration of the ways teachers understand and teach critical literacy with English language learners from diverse cultural and linguistic backgrounds. How official policy representations are taken up, rejected, augmented and altered by English language

teachers is explored. The ways in which these empirical findings can provide insights for those teaching in other global educational contexts is also explored.

Critical Literacy with Adolescent English Language Learners is a timely and important book because it provides comparative analysis of the official position of critical literacy in English language education policy for adolescents in four global contexts, while also providing rich, empirical data from classrooms and interviews as to what teachers of English language learners do with policy in everyday practice. Against a backdrop of “quality assurance” and accountability discourses in language and literacy education policy globally (Luke, 2003), the book provides evidence of the selection of critical literacy practices that are valued by teachers who work with linguistically and culturally diverse groups of learners. It also highlights the gaps that both policy and practice need to consider more closely.

The central theme of this book is the importance of providing advanced critical literacy education for English language learners who are often new-comers to neo-liberal socio-political landscapes such as Australia. These learners are often given modified teaching programs based on functional approaches to literacy that deny them opportunities to engage critically with texts. As Luke (2013) argues “migrant working class kids are getting basic skills and not the intellectual rigour that others get”. However, these learners, like any others, need to know how to read the word and the world critically (Freire & Macedo, 1987) in order to navigate, with agency, new and complex cultural encounters that involve understanding English as their second or even third language.

In particular, the book aims to extend the conversation around the ways in which critical literacy teaching might be enacted via affective means (Janks, 2010; Lewis, 2014). To do this, I present analysis of the ways in which one teacher, Celia, drew attention to the nexus between the aesthetic appreciation of the beauty of language and a rationalist critical interrogation of the power of language.

The book aims to

- provide rich, comparative evidence of constructions of critical literacy in current English teaching policy for adolescent English language learners in Australia, UK, Sweden and the US;
- review key, current literature that describes successful use of critical literacy with adolescent ELLs in global contexts;
- offer detailed accounts of three specialist English language teachers’ orientations to critical literacy, drawing on Janks’ (2010) internationally renowned and highly regarded Synthesis Model of Critical Literacy. This includes documentation of what the teachers think critical literacy is and how they practice it in their classrooms. This book reports on how the teachers demonstrate productive and contingent orientations to critical literacy, allowing further discussion of what is missing and might be added to their practice;

- demonstrate, through detailed analysis of transcripts of classroom discourse/interaction, how such teachers productively enact a critical approach to learning the English language in their contexts with their particular diverse learners;
- add to the fledgling literature on ‘critical aesthetics’ by providing analysis of a fourth teacher and her attempts to marry emotional engagement and aesthetic appreciation of text with a rationalist critical approach to analysing power in language.

The Genesis

This book arose out of my experience as a teacher educator working with teachers of English in Brisbane high schools in 2009. The teachers were faced with increasing numbers of immigrant English language learners, and a curriculum that espoused an analytical critical literacy approach with little professional support to develop teachers to enact it. They were at a loss. How were they to work with important, complex critical literacy concepts with these young adults who were still learning to comprehend English? At a professional development meeting I ran, the teachers vocalised their deep frustration at wanting to help their learners read the world while these learners struggled to even read the word in English. For many of their learners, those from impoverished backgrounds with interrupted schooling, this seemed just too difficult to achieve. Knowing that teachers are an agentive and creative lot (having been one myself since 1987 in some so called “tough” schools), I didn’t give up on these teachers finding a solution and, thankfully, neither did they.

Critical Literacy with Adolescent English Language Learners provides hopeful stories about what teachers can do to make critical literacy possible with high school learners for whom English is an additional language, and for whom ‘criticality’ may be a foreign concept. It draws on a year-long, case study research project conducted in two, differing urban Australian high schools. The four teachers, three female and one male, were experienced teachers of English and expressed interest in critical literacy, with differing understandings of it as will be shown in the ensuing chapters. Their students were in Year 11 and 12, the final years of high school, and were undertaking a rigorous, required senior English syllabus prepared for English language learners. This long-fought-for syllabus permitted them access to tertiary education courses and was an achievable alternative to the mainstream English syllabus undertaken by their English-speaking peers that assumed much English language and dominant culture knowledge. At the time of the study, the syllabus was in its fourth year of use and was still known as an “extended trial” syllabus. Today, it is a fully- fledged English syllabus – one of a suite of four syllabuses on offer to senior high school students in Australia.

The research in this book will be of interest to language education policy-makers and curriculum designers as it presents analysis of how international policies construct ‘the critical’, and examples of how teachers work within given

policy parameters in agentive ways. Equally, it will be of interest to teachers seeking to find practical ways to enact critical literacy with English language learners in high school settings where English is the dominant language.

How is this book unique?

While there are a number of useful books already available on critical literacy (for example, Janks, Dixon, Ferreira, Granville & Newfield, 2014; Lewison, Leland & Harste, 2015; Rogers, Winters, Perry & La Monda, 2015; Yoon & Sharif, 2015; Zacher Pandya & Ávila, 2014), this book adds to researchers' and the teachers' bookshelves for a number of reasons:

- English Language Learners are in sharp focus in this book. Some learners in the case studies have low English language proficiency levels and they are from a broad range of cultural and linguistic backgrounds and visa categories for example, Afghanistan, Burundi, China, Congo, Japan, Sudan, Somalia, Russia. The question in focus is how can teachers teach critical literacy with these students in order to provide equitable educational opportunity and outcomes?
- The focus is adolescent learners particularly in the upper high school, about which there is sparse literature relating to critical literacy.
- The assessment stakes are higher in the pre-tertiary, high school context and this has a significant impact on the teachers' decision making regarding critical literacy, especially within assessment. In Queensland, Australia, the state where this study was conducted, the assessment of learners in their final year of high school English has now moved to an external exam worth 25%. Previously, the entire English score was based on school-based assessment verified at district panels. Now, assessment is shared with an external examination marked by independent, trained graders. This will have a significant, and as yet unknown, effect on the ways critical literacy is taken up, or otherwise, in teachers' practice.
- The book provides a compelling overview of the place of critical literacy in English language education policy in five countries. Policy matters; it can influence teachers and it can also be resisted so it is important to understand the broader backdrop of policy and curriculum that affects teachers' work regarding critical literacy. This book provides a discussion of key international policies that shape the possibilities for critical literacy work. These are not presented geopolitically by country but are grouped according to the affordances for critical literacy they offer teachers and learners.
- Interview and classroom observation data are provided showing four teachers' key orientations to critical literacy using Janks' (2010) model as explanatory framework. This is actual, naturally-occurring teacher practice, not model practice or interventions. Other possibilities for practice are explored and discussed in relation to policy.

- Critical Aesthetics is a special focus given it is highly topical at the time of writing this book. Data from one teacher demonstrating how she combined an emerging focus on *affect* and *critique* will be presented.

These distinctive features of the book contribute another lens on critical literacy work being conducted globally. It is intended to add to the rich discussions already taking place and to be a catalyst for others to research critical literacy education with English language learners in their own contexts.

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Jennifer Alford, Brisbane, Australia.

Permissions from journals:

Permission to use Lau *Figure 1 An integrated CL instruction model* in [Chapter 3](#) – Lau, S. M. C. (2013). A study of critical literacy work with beginning English language learners: An integrated approach. *Critical Inquiry in Language Studies*, 10(1), 1–30. doi: [10.1080/15427587.2013.753841](https://doi.org/10.1080/15427587.2013.753841).

Permission to use [Table 5.1](#) in [Chapter 5](#) –

Alford, J., & Jetnikoff, A. (2016). Orientations to critical literacy for English as an additional language or dialect (EAL/D) learners: A case study of four teachers of senior English. *Australian Journal of Language and Literacy*, 39(2), 111–123. Granted by Australian Literacy Educators' Association (ALEA).

Permission to use [Figure 4.2](#) *The critical literacy 'spice words' Marcus expects to see in their analytical essays (whiteboard summary)* in [Chapter 4](#) –

Alford, J. H. & Jetnikoff, A. (2011). High-challenge teaching for senior English as an Additional Language (EAL) learners in times of change. *English in Australia*, 46(1), pp. 11–20.

List of abbreviations

ACARA	Australian Curriculum and Assessment Reporting Authority (national)
CCSS	Common Core State Standards (USA)
CDA	Critical Discourse Analysis
EAL	English as an Additional Language
ELL	English Language Learners (USA and Canada)
ELA	English Language Arts (curriculum)
ESL	English as a Second Language
L1	first language
L2	second or target language
SFL	Systemic Functional Linguistics
QCAA	Queensland Curriculum and Assessment Authority (state body of ACARA)

1 What is critical literacy and why is it important for adolescent learners of English as an Additional Language (EAL) now?

In a peaceful world without the threat of global warming or conflict or war, where everyone has access to education, health care, food and a dignified life, there would still be a need for critical literacy.

(Janks, 2012, p. 150)

This chapter builds on the Preface where the rationale for the book was outlined and where I introduced the book's focus. To set the scene for the analysis and argument presented in this book, this first chapter asserts the importance of providing critical literacy education for adolescent English as an Additional Language (EAL) learners amid continued "mutterings about it being passé" (Janks, 2014, p. 32). Those who consider it passé fail to recognise that critical approaches to education always gain traction for a reason; as a way to give voice to a range of positions, not just those of the dominant, and to challenge inequity. As Janks (2014) strongly maintains, a critical stance to text cannot be dismissed as irrelevant, because "an understanding of the power of texts to shape identities and construct knowledge is perhaps even more pressing in an interconnected globalised world with ever more complex forms of text production and dissemination" (p. 37). A critical stance is also important from a curriculum perspective for EAL learners as competing agendas, serving neo-liberal, market-driven outcomes, have resulted in the systematic "elbowing out" of the critical (see Leung, 2016). This is occurring in contexts marked by rapid global mobility where learners represent diverse backgrounds, cultures, and language groups. Classrooms globally are now characterised by "superdiversity" or the complex nature of multicultural communities due to diffuse migration patterns since the 1990s (Vertovec, 2007; Blommaert & Rampton, 2012). English language learners, as members of these multicultural communities are often subjected to modified teaching programs that foreground basic, functional approaches to literacy (Lau, 2012; Locke & Cleary, 2011), and monolingual ideologies (French, 2016; Garcia, Flores & Woodley, 2012; Lam, 2006;) that deny them opportunities to engage critically with texts (Morell, 2008). As Luke (2013) has argued, migrant, working class kids are only getting the basic skills and not the intellectual rigour offered to others.

2 What and why critical literacy is important

However, “migrant kids” need to know how to read the word and the world critically (Freire & Macedo, 1987) in order to navigate new and complex cultural encounters that involve understanding English as their second or even third or fourth language. In fact, Scorza, Mirra, and Morrell (2013) assert that critical literacy should be normalised as a feature of academic excellence for all young people in schools, in order to subvert ‘the banking model’ of education (Freire, 1970) that still persists today. Normalising critical literacy in the pursuit of academic quality is especially important for adolescent learners of English who are making life-directing decisions while living in unfamiliar socio-cultural environments and operating in a dominant language (e.g., English) which they are still mastering. The reasons why critical literacy is crucial for EAL learners are discussed further in this chapter. In focussing on EAL learners this book contributes to the emerging body of critical literacy research “that account(s) for rapid cultural globalisation, diasporic communities, cultural communities and hybridised critical literacy practices as tied to the movement and flow of communities experiencing migration and transmigration” (Mills, 2016, p. 63).

The learners that this book focuses on are referred to as *English as an Additional Language* (EAL) learners. A relatively new term in the UK and Australia, EAL “refers to the fact that pupils may use one or more languages other than English in their everyday lives. The term provides scope for languages other than English to be recognised and incorporated into students’ educational experience. The use of the term EAL means that learning English should be viewed as adding to students’ capacities as bilingual or multilingual learners, rather than displacing the language/s that students may have acquired earlier” (Bracken, Driver, & Kadi-Hanifi, 2017, p. 14). The terms used in global literature and policy are varied and can be confusing. The term English as a Second Language (ESL) is often used, however many students who are learning English in schools already speak two or more languages. The word “additional” better captures their experiences and needs, represents an additive not subtractive view of bilingualism (Baker, 2011). In the US, the term English Language Learners (ELLs) is more common but this has also come into question of late for its potential to stigmatise learners as deficient in English, the point of reference, rather than as speakers of their own languages. Regardless of how we label them for our convenience, English as an additional language learners are new to learning social and academic English in schools and are often but not always new-comers to “Western” neo-liberal, socio-political contexts.

EAL learners are often cast in deficit terms as a convenient way to explain poor performance (see Alford, 2014). Those who adhere to a deficit view allege, that “deficits manifest ...in limited intellectual abilities, linguistic shortcomings, lack of motivation to learn, and immoral behavior” (Valencia, 2010, p. 27). Deficit thinking is common among many teachers of culturally and linguistically diverse students (Luke et al., 2013), even among well-meaning teachers

(Lam, 2006) and even those who have long challenged deficit discourses about EAL students (Dooley, 2012). Deficit thinking is part of a pervasive discourse that is hard to shift. It serves certain members of the community and not others. A deficit discourse is grounded in cultural mismatch theory which “locates its explanation of the underperformance or underachievement of non-dominant students in the nonalignment of the cultural practices of the home and school” (Gutierrez, Zitali Morales, & Martinez, 2009, p. 218). Ascribing failure to individual students’ traits, their cultural backgrounds and home languages, has led to labelling students as “low achievers” (Gutierrez et al., 2009) and “problems” (Cummins, 2003; Gutierrez & Orellana, 2006a, 2006b; Sharp, 2012). This labelling assumes that participation in education programs is available for all, but that the learners’ own characteristics preclude prevent them from taking advantage of these (Valencia, 1997).

Difference is often a comparative term that uses dominant communities as the norm; the reference point for judging others. This approach to difference “highlights what students from non-dominant communities are not” (Gutierrez et al., 2009, p. 222). Student struggle at school is assigned to the fact that they are different from the dominant norm. Student characteristics are seen, in this view, as monolithic and not shifting, deficient, and dichotomous to education organised by dominant communities (Gutierrez et al., 2009).

When difference is viewed more delicately, an alternative view is possible. For Dooley (2008), difference includes interests, values, dispositions, sensibilities, perspectives, capabilities and preferences for making knowledge, and styles of thinking, communicating and relating with others (p. 105). As such, the particular mix of life world differences in any one person will be unique, regardless of whether they share the above mentioned general demographic categories with others (Dooley, 2008). An EAL student may be more different from another EAL learner than from a student who shares fully the language and culture of the dominant community. Also, differences such as interests, values, dispositions etcetera cannot be seen to be outside of or dichotomous to schooling. As Dooley (2008) also notes, they arise from everyday social interaction within a given field, including classroom interaction.

A deficit view of learners provides an ideological platform to *not* create robust, intellectually challenging curriculum and classroom practice for EAL learners; it becomes an escape hatch. Critical literacy, for example, is relegated to the “too hard basket” or treated as irrelevant. While this unfortunately holds true for many contexts, particularly low SES communities of colour in the US (Valencia, 2010) and among some areas of high diversity and high poverty in Australia, promising practice can be observed. There are growing reports of intellectually challenging practice with adolescent EAL learners that refuse the deficit model and instead scaffold learners to reach intellectual output comparable to those who are not seen through a deficit lens (Alford, 2014; Alford & Jetnikoff, 2016; Lau, 2013; Lau, 2015; Lau, Juby-Smith, & Desbiens, 2017; Hammond, 2008; Morrell, 2008).

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Against this backdrop of deficit and its challengers, the questions this book probes are: How do English language education policies and curricula in different global contexts prioritise critical literacy, if at all, for EAL learners? What is happening in English language learning classrooms that do engage with critical approaches to literacy? What can all this teach us about how critical literacy is both made available and obscured for EAL learners at this point in time?

Teachers' voices on what critical literacy is: Four snapshots

Rather than begin with how theories and models define critical literacy, I begin here with the perspectives of four high school teachers' who work on a daily basis with culturally and linguistically diverse youth. Teachers' work is often unacknowledged but their work and views matter significantly in how teaching and learning gets done. This book is partly about policy and how it discursively constructs official representations of theories and models of literacy teaching, but it is teachers who have substantial power to interpret and make possible varying approaches through enactment (Alford & Kettle, 2017; Comber & Nixon, 2009; Garcia & Menken, 2015). At the outset of my year-long ethnographically-informed research in urban Australian high schools, I asked each of the four participating teachers in individual interviews what they understood critical literacy to be. Here are some of their responses:

MARGOT: *I guess critical literacy is a matter of thinking more deeply about how society works, how institutions work. Understanding the rights that they (students) have because ...the thing is, if you don't have any knowledge you accept everything at face value; it's very easy for you to be controlled by individuals, institutions. You know, you become disempowered. So I think that critical literacy is about their (students') development as an individual and where they fit into our society.*

RIVA: *it's an understanding of the way language works to do more than just carry information; it conveys information but it persuades, it distributes power and affects relationships and I can't say this without using the critical language - privileging, marginalising, silencing. I think that's what language does.*

LUCAS: *I think that when you're looking at a text from a critical perspective that you've got to take into account that it is a representation of a specific time and a specific place that has produced that text, and that may or may not berelevant anymore; it may or may not represent truth as you know it or knowledge as you know it. I think that you can discover those aspects when you approach (literacy) from a critical perspective, as opposed to you know, just the words on the page, where you might look at the language and the themes but not how that language and those themes have been constructed for a specific purpose.*

CELIA: *I think critical literacy is getting involved in your reading. You might want to take something personally or you might want to reject it and say, "I don't agree with this at all." I guess critical literacy is knowing that you have the power to do that and that you are aware of where you stand as far as a particular text is concerned, so... you can become emotionally involved with a text. I think that that's being critically literate as well.*

The selection of quotes above presents a range of conceptualisations about what critical literacy is, from teachers' perspectives. These understandings range from: *teaching about rights and empowerment within institutions*, to *knowing how language distributes power and influences relationships*, to *exploring representations of truth and knowledge in texts*, to *getting involved personally and emotionally with texts*. They offer glimpses into how critical literacy is being understood and practised in everyday classrooms, by teachers on the 'front-line' (Griffith & Smith, 2014; Snyder, 2008) in everyday school contexts. As noted in the Preface, this book is interested in the range of possible ways of demarcating critical literacy discursively, in English language education policy and the research literature, and more specifically, how it is defined and then enacted in teachers' practice within the field of English language teaching for adolescents who speak home languages other than English.

In the following section, I outline key ways in which critical literacy is being defined in influential literature. I also present a focus on how critical literacy is defined within the sub-field of English language teaching for adolescents/young adults who speak home languages other than standard varieties of English¹. These definitions contribute, in part, to the *discursive formation* that constitutes critical literacy or the established order of critical literacy 'truth' that organises language and regulates communicative practices at a particular point in time (Foucault, 1972). Discursive possibilities are shifting and come in and out of focus in policy and practice over the course of time, depending on related social, cultural and political changes. What is visible and sayable about critical literacy becomes that which we can draw on, until someone proffers something new. Fairclough (2003), drawing on Archer (2000), notes, though, that teachers have *agency* within discursive formations and can take up, adapt or resist existing constructions of 'truth' and associated practices. Adding to the conceptualisation of agency among teachers in particular, Priestley, Biesta and Robinson (2013) argue that teachers have a particular kind of agency. In their model, agency is contextually located and consists of the teachers' previous life and professional experiences, their creative configurations of future goals, and their present judgements amid the contextual constraints in their educational institution. Learning how teachers agentively work with critical literacy is the focus of [Chapters 4](#) and [5](#) where I explore how they recontextualise constructions of critical literacy from often vague curricular documents into their own classrooms in Australia, a country marked by linguistic diversity within the population but a monolingual mindset within education (Coleman, 2012; Cross, 2012; Garcia, Flores & Woodley, 2012; Lam, 2006).

Critical literacy – Origins and definitions

Critical literacy has been a topic of interest in literacy education for nearly 50 years and distillation of it to one “method” is actively resisted by educators (Luke, 2000, 2012; Pandya & Ávila, 2014). It has “defied a unified curricula approach” (Behrman, 2006, p. 490). This is because moulding and deploying “the tools, attitudes and philosophies of critical literacy ... depends upon students’ and teachers’ everyday relations or power, their lived problems and struggles ... and on educators’ professional ingenuity in navigating the enabling and disabling local contexts of policy” (Luke, 2012, p. 9).

Critical literacy’s origins lie in critical social theory (The Frankfurt School) and its concern with class, gender and ethnicity, and how these sociocultural variables interface with scientific progress and capitalism. At its roots lie Marxist notions of economic oppression but later, a broader interest developed in the ideologies that shape social life and the transformative possibilities they provide. Freire’s landmark book *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1970), based on his work with poor populations in Brazil provided a link between critical theory and literacy education. The book offered a view of education that required critique of existing forms of knowledge and their reproduction so that education could be socially transformative, especially for those experiencing poverty. Freire, with Macedo in 1987, presented a pedagogic model of problem posing and dialogue to explore critical, political questions about the world in which people live. Known as *critical pedagogy*, the approach has been taken up worldwide and has revolutionised the way education is enacted in many classrooms and communities more broadly. Educators’ interest in the power that language, specifically, plays in critiquing political injustice has burgeoned into what we now know as *critical literacy*.

In the 1970s and 1980s, critical education theorists such as Apple (1979), Giroux (1992), Giroux and Simon (1988), McLaren (1988), and Shor (1980) shed light on the hidden curriculum of schooling practices that maintain unequal power relations and serve the interests of the privileged. Following this trend, various researchers (Auerbach, 1995; Canagarajah, 1999; Fairclough, 1992, 1995; Luke, 1995; Pennycook, 1999, 2001; Wallace, 1992, 1995) began to argue that language education is also a socio-political practice when dominant cultural and linguistic forms and practices are imposed on learners. The second language education research agenda according to Kumaravadivelu (1999) began to include the collection and analysis of data on the implementation of critical literacy in the late 1990s. This is despite the fact that critical approaches have been available as a teaching focus for language educators since the 1970s (Freire, 1972; Freire & Macedo, 1987) and have been promoted institutionally as necessary for well-rounded language and literacy education since the early 1990s (Freebody & Luke, 1990; Janks, 1991; Janks & Ivanic, 1992). In 1999, in an influential issue of *TESOL Quarterly*, Pennycook advocated that critical approaches to teaching English to speakers of other languages (TESOL) should be seen “not as a static body of knowledge and practices but rather as always

being in flux, always questioning, restively problematising the given, being aware of the limits of their own knowing, and bringing into being new schemas of politicisation” (Pennycook, 1999, p. 329).

Broadly speaking, critical literacy is the study of language in use that:

... focuses on teaching and learning how texts work, understanding and re-mediating what texts attempt to do in the world and to people, and moving students toward active position-taking with texts to critique and reconstruct the social fields in which they live and work.

(Luke, 2000, p. 460).

The above quote demonstrates the complex territory that critical literacy encapsulates: deconstructing, re-mediating and reconstructing meaning-making and hints that it is always a “historical, materialist work in progress” (Luke, 2014, p. 29). Luke, Comber, and O’Brien’s (1994) definition of the term “critical” has been instrumental in developing many Australian teachers’ understandings of what critical literacy is:

By “critical” we mean ways that give students tools for weighing and critiquing, analysing and appraising the textual techniques and ideologies, values and positions. The key challenge ... is how to engage students with the study of “how texts work” semiotically and linguistically, while at the same time taking up explicitly how texts and their associated social institutions work politically to construct and position writers and readers in relations of power and knowledge (or lack thereof). (p. 35).

The interest for critical literacy is in how texts work, what texts do to us, and how we can manage the ways in which they seek to work. Questioning and attendant discussion or dialogue are central to critical literacy practice. Questions that guide learners in being critically literate include:

- Who do you think is behind the construction of this text?
 - Whose view of the world is put forth in the text?
 - How are meanings assigned to certain figures or events in the text?
 - Where does the text come from (historical/cultural)?
 - What social function does it serve?
 - How far do you accept the text’s/author’s position?
 - What other positions might there be?
 - Who has a voice in the text?
 - How else might these characters’ stories be told?
 - Are there silent voices that are not immediately apparent?
 - How might the text be rewritten to give voice to the silenced?
- (Soares & Watson, 2006, p. 56)

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Learners are cast in the role of active questioner rather than acquiescent receiver of the materials presented to them in classrooms. In this way both learners and teachers are re-positioned in relation to each other, and to forms of knowledge. As Mills (2016) asserts, critical literacy approaches “reposition teachers and students to deconstruct dominant selective traditions in schools and society, particularly in the complex textual and multimedia environments of navigating and remixing digitally mediated texts.” (p. 42).

Within high school English teaching in the United States, Morrell’s (2008) definition remains influential:

A critical English education is explicit about the role of language and literacy in conveying meaning and in promoting or disrupting existing power relations. It also seeks to develop in young women and men skills to deconstruct dominant texts carefully (i.e., canonical literature, media texts) while also instructing them in skills that allow them to create their own critical texts that can be used in the struggle for social justice. Further, critical English education encourages practitioners to draw upon the everyday language and literacy practices of adolescents to make connections with academic literacies and to work toward empowered identity development and social transformation. (p. 313)

Similarly, Morgan (1997), writing for Australian English teachers over two decades ago, asserts that critical literacy teachers “focus on the cultural and ideological assumptions that underwrite texts, they investigate the politics of representation, and they interrogate the inequitable, cultural positioning of speakers and readers within discourse” (pp. 1–2).

Janks (2000, 2010, 2012, 2013), working in the vastly diverse South African context, offers a comprehensive view of what critical literacy teaching involves, expanding understandings of how the critical dimension can be brought into our orientations to teaching language and literacy. She argues that there are four main realisations of critical literacy – Domination, Access, Diversity, and Design – and that each of these approaches is based on different conceptions of the relationship between language and power. I have described her approach elsewhere:

Janks maintains that four orientations to the teaching of critical literacy are possible – *Domination*, *Access*, *Diversity* and *Design* – that they are interdependent and need to be held in ‘productive tension to achieve what is a shared goal of all critical literacy work: equity and social justice’ (Janks, 2010, p. 27). *Domination* assumes a critical discourse analysis approach in which the language and images in dominant texts are deconstructed to discover concepts such as fore-groundings, silences and whose interests are served. *Access* involves making explicit the features of the genres that carry social power, for example, analytical essays and reports, hitherto assumed to be already in some learners’ heads. *Diversity* involves drawing on a range of modalities as resources and to include students’ own diverse languages

and literacies. Finally, *Design* asks teachers to harness the productive power of diverse learners to create their own meanings through re-construction of texts. Students use a range of media and technologies to do so without relying on traditional print media. Offering students control over text production, the opportunity to ‘talk back’ to texts and to produce texts that matter to them, is considered important for agency and identity transformation. This model shows the interdependence each dimension has with the other, and critiques unitary orientations that exclude the other dimensions. Any one dimension, without the others, creates an imbalance that denies students the opportunity to experience the full range of critical literacy education.

(Alford & Jetnikoff, 2016, pp. 114–115)

Table 1.1 explains the interdependent elements of Janks’ model and elucidates why it is optimal to weave all four together when teaching critical literacy, in response to local contextual factors. I explicate this model further in Chapter 2,

Table 1.1 The synthesis model of critical literacy (Janks, 2010, p. 26)

Domination without access	This maintains the exclusionary force of dominant discourses.
Domination without diversity	Domination without difference and diversity loses the ruptures that produce contestation and change.
Domination without design	The deconstruction of dominance, without reconstruction or design, removes human agency.
Access without domination	Access without a theory of domination leads to the naturalisation of powerful discourses without an understanding of how these powerful forms came to be powerful.
Access without diversity	This fails to recognise that difference fundamentally affects pathways to access and involves issues of history, identity and value.
Access without design	This maintains and reifies dominant forms without considering how they can be transformed.
Diversity without domination	This leads to a celebration of diversity without any recognition that difference is structured in dominance and that not all discourses/genres/languages/literacies are equally powerful.
Diversity without access	Diversity without access to powerful forms of language ghettoises students.
Diversity without design	Diversity provides the means, the ideas, the alternative perspectives for reconstruction and transformation. Without design, the potential that diversity offers is not realised.
Design without domination	Design without an understanding of how dominant discourses/practices perpetuate themselves, runs the risk of an unconscious reproduction of these forms.
Design without access	This runs the risk of whatever is designed remaining on the margins.
Design without diversity	This privileges dominant forms and fails to use the design resources provided by difference

and in [Chapter 4](#) I draw on Janks' model as an explanatory framework to analyse four teachers' practice.

As indicated above, critical literacy itself is a work in progress as emergent digital technologies and platforms for interacting present new challenges to what constitutes a text, what critique involves, and with what it is concerned. As Wohlwend and Lewis (2011) have pointed out, "Proliferating technologies and colliding global systems make it paradoxically easier and harder to track the echoes, emanations and effects of widely dispersed, fleeting digital texts" (p. 189). We have come to accept that wide dispersion of texts means, for instance, that multiple reader interpretations exist (influenced by culture) and that these may or may not be known to others near or far. The fleeting nature of texts, though, is much more challenging for educators to work with. Consider Apps such as Snapchat which provides the opportunity to create texts that literally disappear; or Wikipedia which can be altered instantly through deletions and insertions; and even company policies -the fine print we get tripped up by legally- can be written, rewritten and published publicly within a matter of minutes. These textual transformations pose considerable challenges for how teachers include a focus on critical literacy with all learners, including English language learners. Thus, critical literacy and its relationship with texts is itself a moving feast and will remain so.

In addition, current views on critical literacy and its relationship with what constitutes "critique" are being stimulated by challenging questions about the centrality of teachers and the curriculum (Alford & Kettle, 2017) in relation to the centrality of learners. Janks (2014) posits that critique involves "the ability to recognise that the interests of texts do not always coincide with the interests of all and that they are open to reconstruction; the ability to understand that discourses produce us, speak through us, and can nevertheless be challenged and changed; the ability to imagine the possible and actual effects of texts and to evaluate these in relation to an ethics of social justice and care" (p. 42). Recent work by Pandya (2019) in California offers valuable insights into the everyday critique practices found in children's video-making and the possibilities for redistributive social justice this offers teachers, children and communities. In Pandya's research, the children were not fully guided in "how to critique" by teachers or the curriculum. Rather, their digital composing practices were ethnographically observed for the kinds of critique they would generate when left largely to their own devices. The children made videos about a "Day in the Life" of a person they knew, and videos about saving their school which was under threat of closure. The study revealed the children taking stances on local issues of social justice through multimodal expression drawing on their own design sensibilities. This kind of research forces us to think more about what critique "looks like" for different people, and what purposes it serves.

At its core, critical literacy is interested in disrupting the commonplace, interrogating multiple viewpoints, focusing on socio-political issues, taking informed action and promoting social justice (Lewison, Flint, & van Sluys, 2002). A more expansive discussion of six significant instructional models of

critical literacy is presented in [Chapter 3](#) as a backdrop to the exploration of teachers' practice.

Why is critical literacy important for EAL learners?

Apart from the reasons given already in this chapter for why critical literacy is important for adolescents in general, it is particularly significant for EAL learners. The term “EAL learners” encapsulates a decidedly heterogeneous group that make up a significant proportion of school populations, enough to warrant explicit policy statements on how to cater for them, at least in some contexts. Yet, they are routinely conceived of as “different from” the mainstream. This notion of difference is an important one for establishing why critical literacy is fundamental for EAL learners. Difference is, according to Janks (2012), always structured in relation to power. As a result, those deemed “different” to those in power – be it on the basis of gender identification, class, or ethnicity – typically have unequal access to resources. This is the case for newly arrived EAL learners, and even those who have spent years in their adopted countries, who are navigating texts in unfamiliar linguistic, socio-cultural, economic and political landscapes. They have an urgent need for access to education resources that enable them to read the textual terrain - the cultural, political and economic context framing texts - in such a way that offers them the possibility of meaningful social and political participation and engagement. Luke and Dooley (2011) provide a succinct statement about critical literacy that outlines the import of a text/context focus for EAL learners in particular:

Critical literacy approaches view texts – print and multimodal, paper-based and digital - and their codes and discourses as human technologies for representing and reshaping possible worlds. Texts are not taken as part of a canonical curriculum tradition or received wisdom that is beyond criticism. Rather they are conceived of as malleable human designs and artefacts used in social fields. In this regard, *critical approaches begin by culturally and historically situating languages and discourses, texts, their authors and readers – bracketing and disrupting their “natural”, given or taken-for-granted authoritative status in institutional and everyday contexts*. Texts, then, operate in identifiable social, cultural and political contexts. The aim is *to develop learners capable of critiquing and making texts in their cultural and community interests*. This involves an understanding of how texts and discourses can be constructed, deconstructed and reconstructed to represent, contest and, indeed, transform material, social and semiotic relations.

(p. 856, my emphasis)

Critical literacy has other benefits for often marginalised additional language learners as well (Clark, 1995; Janks, 1999; Wallace, 1992, 1995, 2013). For example, drawing on these learners' perspectives and interpretations can reposition these students away from the edges of institutional learning (Moje, Young,

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Readence, & Moore, 2000). Additionally, critical literacy may help students develop empathy through a focus on human rights and social justice. Henkin (2005) notes that critical literacy is “central to creating democratic, fair, and hate-free schools that confront all forms of bullying and harassment” (p. ix). When mobilized in classrooms comprised of both EAL and non-EAL learners, it can shift entrenched conceptions of the “other”, and unite learners in common causes.

Perhaps most significantly, critical approaches to second language teaching are a curriculum strategy to address educational disadvantage: “Critical approaches to TESOL attempt to shift the balance of conventional TESOL, focusing on the enfranchisement of the life worlds and voices of students’ communities and cultures and a direct engagement with codes and texts of power” (Luke & Dooley, 2011, p. 861). Endorsing and providing critical approaches to literacy education for EAL learners can help them to develop and mobilise mature responses, rather than ill-informed, reactionary, radicalised or populist political and micro-political choices. This book is interested, then, in the situated “reading of the world” by teachers and the assumptions that lead them to enact critical literacy in particular ways with culturally and linguistically diverse learners of English. It is also interested in whether and how the teachers, within the bounds of their contexts, were enabled to create English language and literacy education that had the potential to alter their learners’ analysis of and action in the world.

Structure of this book

Subsequent chapters are organised as follows. [Chapter 2](#) provides a comparative analysis of the ways in which critical literacy is constructed in curricula in five global contexts – the US with a focus on California; the United Kingdom, Canada, Sweden and Australia. In their chapter in the 2015 Routledge Handbook of Literacy Studies, Rogers and O’Daniels (2015) call for “studies that trace the emergence and development of critical literacy over time and across contexts”. [Chapter 2](#) contributes to this call by tracing how critical literacy for English language learners has been conceptualized across time in English language education curricula (policy) across different global contexts. This chapter traces how critical literacy for English language learners has been conceptualized across time in English language education curricula (policy) across different global contexts. It presents a comparison of how critical literacy is represented and constructed in English language education policy for high school adolescent ELLs. The key focus is: what’s in and what’s out in the age of intensifying assessment requirements and measurability? The chapter will begin with an exploration of the nature of policy – “policy as text” and “policy as discourse”, as noted by Ball (1993, 2015). This is followed by an explanation of the method used in the policy analysis– Fairclough’s (2003) Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA). Fairclough’s framework provides a way of investigating ideology as it is played out across time in language within actual practices in social institutions, such as the production of policy. CDA is a useful tool to explore the ways that the

educational language policies of any country reflect not only social judgements about language, but about other elements as well, such as which groups in society are afforded which educational priorities (McGroarty, 2002; Rogers, 2011). Australia, the UK and the US, in particular, have seen critical literacy wax and wane in official English language education policies for adolescents since the late 1990s. The chapter traces these shifts and presents the current situation for each country comparatively.

Chapter 3 provides a review of the literature investigating critical literacy classroom practice with adolescent English language learners. It begins with a review of selected empirical studies of teachers' understandings and practice of critical literacy with ELLs in high schools in a range of global settings over the past decade. Following this, the chapter presents an overview of "good practice" of critical literacy, as proposed by six instructional models, which I explore in turn drawing out their affordances and the synergies between them. I also offer suggestions for how affect or emotion can be factored into many of the existing instructional models of critical literacy.

Chapter 4 reports analysis of empirical data gathered through studies of regular teacher practice and their articulated knowledge of critical literacy in two high schools in Queensland, Australia. The chapter begins with an overview of the context of teaching critical literacy in Australia at the time of the data collection. Details of the specific contexts of data collection will also be given, that is, two contrasting urban high schools. The theorised methods of analysis used in the case studies drawn from Fairclough's critical discourse analysis (2003) are presented. This involved coupling Fairclough's concepts of Genres, Discourses, and Styles with Janks' Orientations to Critical Literacy in her Synthesis Model (Janks, 2010) – Access, Domination, Diversity and Design. In this way, the book also provides a theoretical and methodological contribution to this kind of research that others may find useful. The four teachers' knowledge and practice is discussed based on the orientations that were most evident in their talk and practice.

In Chapter 5, a cross-case synthesis is provided to draw together the evidence of practice across the four cases discussed in Chapter 4, in relation to the English language education policy in Australia at that time. This chapter shows the relationship between shifting policy (as shown in Chapter 2) and how it is taken up and recontextualised (Bernstein, 1990; Fairclough, 2003) by teachers using their own knowledge base and agency in different contexts (as shown in Chapter 4). It will also discuss how a lack of focus on certain aspects of critical literacy in policy is reflected in classroom practice. Readers are encouraged to investigate the relationship between critical literacy in policy and in practice in their own specific contexts. This provides a rich platform for then discussing the possibilities for future practice in Australia and other countries presently undergoing a neo-liberal momentum that is contributing to a shrinking policy imagination (Doherty, 2015), in this case imagining the incorporation of critical literacy into English language education curriculum for multilingual, immigrant learners. Possibilities for future practice are discussed.

To conclude the book, Chapter 6 reiterates the key points made in the preceding chapters and reinforces the importance of Critical Literacy with Adolescent English Language Learners who are making key decisions about tertiary study, work, civic engagement and relationships, for example. This book argues we need a better understanding of how critical literacy is enacted in the everyday classrooms of teachers who work in complex, shifting, multilingual settings with adolescent English language learners in different global contexts. It also argues that policy-makers and education jurisdictions in charge of curricula need to consider the reality of these classrooms when decisions are made about what kinds of critical literacy agendas are included in or omitted from policy.

Note

1. Within the teaching of English, Standard Australian English (SAE) is the only language variety recognised officially in Australian schools in terms of instructional mode and in school-based and standardised assessment.

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